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THE PRISM EFFECT

How Do Changes in Social Identity Refract Economic Decision-Making

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Research Problem

Classical economic models generally analyse decision-making through preferences, incentives, and constraints, while behavioural economics has broadened this perspective by showing that psychological and cognitive processes can also influence how individuals evaluate alternatives and outcomes. Social identity introduces a further dimension to this analysis. Individuals can hold multiple social identities derived from socially meaningful groups and roles, and these identities may be associated with distinct norms, expectations, and behavioural orientations that can become relevant to decision-making [1]–[4].

However, individuals may simultaneously occupy multiple social roles, while the relative salience of these identities can vary across situations [3], [5], [6]. The same individual may therefore approach an otherwise comparable economic decision differently when the social context changes. The research problem concerns whether changes in the relative salience of existing identities can contribute to systematic within-person differences in economic decision-making. Existing perspectives explain why identity salience varies across contexts and how identity-related norms can influence economic valuation [6]–[8], but they do not fully articulate how changes in the relative salience of coexisting identities may alter the priorities guiding an economic decision. The central theoretical problem is therefore not simply whether identity influences behaviour, but how shifts in the relative salience of existing identities may alter the priorities through which economic choices are approached.

Research Questions

The study addresses:

1. How do changes in social identity refract economic decision-making?
2. Do economic choices vary across different social identity contexts within the same individual?
3. Are changes in economic choices associated with changes in the priorities activated by different social identities?
4. How do individuals justify their economic decisions across different social identity contexts?

Existing Literature

Social Identity Theory defines social identity as part of an individual's self-concept derived from perceived membership in socially meaningful groups [1]. Self-Categorization Theory further suggests that the relative salience of these identities can vary according to context, making associated norms and expectations more psychologically relevant [2]. Identity Theory similarly considers the relationship between social structures, identities, and their activation within social contexts [3]. Research on multiple identities indicates that individuals can simultaneously hold several identities whose salience varies across situations [4], [5], while a social economics perspective emphasises the interaction between individual and collective

identities in economic behaviour [14]. Experimental research further shows that identity salience can alter self-perception and the processing of identity-relevant information [6], [7].

Identity Economics extends these insights to economic behaviour by proposing that identity-related norms can affect the value attached to different actions [8]. Experimental research has also linked social identity to differences in social and economic preferences [9], [10]. Identity-Based Motivation provides a further link between identity and decision-making by suggesting that identities can make particular goals, interpretations, and courses of action more motivationally relevant in a given context [11]. Behavioural theories address subsequent stages of economic evaluation: Prospect Theory proposes that outcomes are evaluated relative to reference points [12], while Motivated Reasoning suggests that goals can influence how individuals process and interpret information [13]. Together, these perspectives identify several components through which social context may relate to economic choice, from identity salience and identity-related norms to motivational priorities and evaluation.

However, these relationships are generally examined at separate stages. The present research brings them together within the same decision-maker and across otherwise comparable economic contexts, examining whether changes in the relative salience of pre-existing identities are associated with changes in the priorities and choices through which economic decisions are approached. This provides the conceptual basis for the Prism Effect developed in the present study.

Conceptual Framework

This research proposes the Prism Effect as a conceptual framework for explaining how changes in the relative salience of pre-existing social identities may be associated with variation in economic decision-making within the same individual. The framework conceptualises social identity as a dynamic system of coexisting identities whose salience varies across contexts [3]–[7]. When a particular identity becomes more salient, its associated goals, values, norms, and expectations may receive greater relative priority when approaching an otherwise comparable economic decision [8], [11].

The proposed pathway is therefore: Social Context → Relative Identity Salience → Motivational Priorities → Economic Evaluation → Economic Decision. The framework does not assume that identity directly determines behaviour, nor that a change in salience necessarily produces a different choice. Instead, it proposes a testable pathway through which contextual changes in identity salience may alter the priorities brought to an economic trade-off and thereby contribute to systematic within-person variation in economic choice. Participants' reported priorities and open-ended justifications provide complementary observable evidence of this process, while the study remains associative rather than a formal test of causal mediation.

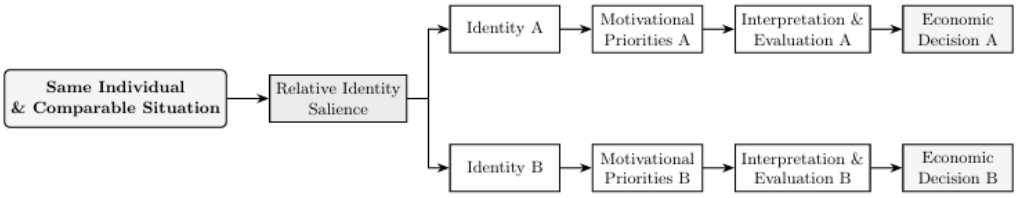


Figure 1

Proposed Prism Effect pathway.

Note. The framework proposes a within-person pathway through which contextual changes in the relative salience of pre-existing social identities may alter the priorities brought to otherwise comparable economic trade-offs.

Methodology

1. **Research Design:** The study uses an exploratory within-person repeated-measures design complemented by a qualitative follow-up. Each of the 100 participants evaluates two economic dilemmas under four contextual role perspectives, producing 800 decision observations. This design allows the same individual to be compared across contexts rather than comparing different groups of participants.
2. **Participants and Procedure:** Data were collected between 20 August and 1 September 2026 through convenience and snowball sampling. Participation was voluntary and anonymous, with informed consent obtained. The four contextual perspectives were Leadership, Vulnerability/Followership, Caregiving, and Personal Financial Identity. Before each block, participants recalled a relevant personal experience and then approached two economic scenarios from that perspective.
3. **Economic Decision Design:** The eight scenarios followed two recurring economic architectures: allocation of limited resources between competing priorities (D1, D3, D5, D7) and security or stability versus potential future gains (D2, D4, D6, D8). Scenarios were contextual adaptations rather than identical repetitions, preserving broadly comparable economic trade-offs while varying the social perspective and consequences attached to them.

Contextual perspective	Economic architecture	Decisions
Leadership	Allocation / Security vs. future gains	D1–D2
Vulnerability/Followership	Allocation / Security vs. future gains	D3–D4
Caregiving	Allocation / Security vs. future gains	D5–D6
Personal Financial Identity	Allocation / Security vs. future gains	D7–D8

Table 1

Within-person structure of the experimental decision design.

Note. Each participant completed two economic decisions within each contextual perspective: one allocation decision and one security-versus-future-gains decision.

4. **Measures and Analysis:** For each decision, participants selected an economic alternative and reported their main consideration, primary objective, and an open-ended

justification. Contextual measures included perceived responsibility or control. Open-ended justifications are analysed thematically to identify recurring reasoning patterns and contextualise quantitative findings.

Differences in choices across contexts are examined using Cochran's Q test [15] and within-person switching measures. Associations between reported priorities and choices are examined using chi-square tests and Cramér's V. Thematic analysis follows established procedures [16].

5. **Qualitative Follow-Up:** Approximately 10 semi-structured interviews complement the survey by exploring how participants interpreted the dilemmas and explained similarities or differences in their reasoning across contexts. The interviews provide additional qualitative evidence for interpreting patterns identified in the quantitative analysis.

Expected Contribution and Conclusion

If the empirical patterns are consistent with the proposed framework, this study would contribute to the understanding of economic decision-making by showing how contextual changes in the relative salience of pre-existing social identities may be associated with systematic within-person variation in economic choices. It would connect identity salience with the motivational priorities individuals report bringing to economic trade-offs, integrating relationships that existing literature has largely examined across separate stages.

This perspective may also have practical relevance to consequential economic decisions in household finance, workplace management, caregiving, and public policy. Recognising that the same individual may approach a decision differently depending on the social perspective activated could inform the design of financial communication, decision-support tools, and interventions that encourage individuals to consider how different priorities shape their choices. More broadly, the study aims to introduce and provide initial empirical grounding for the Prism Effect as a testable framework for understanding how social context may shape the priorities through which economic decisions are approached.

Limitations and Practicalities

Several limitations should guide the interpretation of the findings. The convenience and snowball sampling approach limits the generalisability of the results. In addition, the economic scenarios are designed to preserve comparable trade-offs but are not identical repetitions, meaning that contextual variation cannot be completely separated from differences in scenario content. Finally, reported priorities and open-ended justifications provide observable indicators of participants' stated reasoning rather than direct measures of underlying psychological processes. The findings should therefore be interpreted as exploratory and associative rather than as evidence of causal mediation or definitive changes in economic preferences.

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